



FREE GUIDE • 03

Growing Smiles

Early oral habits that shape how a child's face and jaws develop.

Why the early years matter

A child's face and jaws do most of their growing in the early years, and the muscles of the mouth help steer that growth. When breathing, tongue posture, and swallowing develop well, there is more room for teeth, a wider palate, and a healthier airway. Catching habits early is gentler and more effective than correcting them later.

HABITS TO GENTLY WATCH

- Thumb or finger sucking beyond the toddler years
- Prolonged pacifier or bottle use
- Chronic mouth breathing or an open-mouth rest posture
- Tongue pushing forward when swallowing or talking
- Picky eating, slow eating, or difficulty with textures

TIP

For parents: a quick look

When your child is relaxed and watching TV, glance at their mouth. Are the lips together? Is the breathing quiet and through the nose? Open lips and noisy breathing at rest are worth a closer look.

HOW YOU CAN HELP

- Encourage nose breathing and lips-together rest posture
- Offer varied textures to build strong chewing muscles
- Model calm, closed-mouth breathing yourself
- Keep up with dental and wellness check-ups

When to check in with a professional

Snoring, restless sleep, persistent mouth breathing, or lingering sucking habits are good reasons for an assessment. Early myofunctional support — alongside your dentist or orthodontist — can guide healthy growth at the right time.

This guide is for general education only and is not a substitute for individualized medical or dental advice, diagnosis, or treatment. For a personalized assessment, please reach out to Myo Family Health.

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